

AFRICA

AFRICA IS THE SECOND LARGEST continent in the world. It is nearly three times as big as Europe, but about the same number of people live there. It was cut off from the other continents for millions of years and many of its birds—the ostrich, the shoebill, the secretary bird, as well as turacos, mousebirds, wood hoopoes, and helmet shrikes—are not found anywhere else in the world.

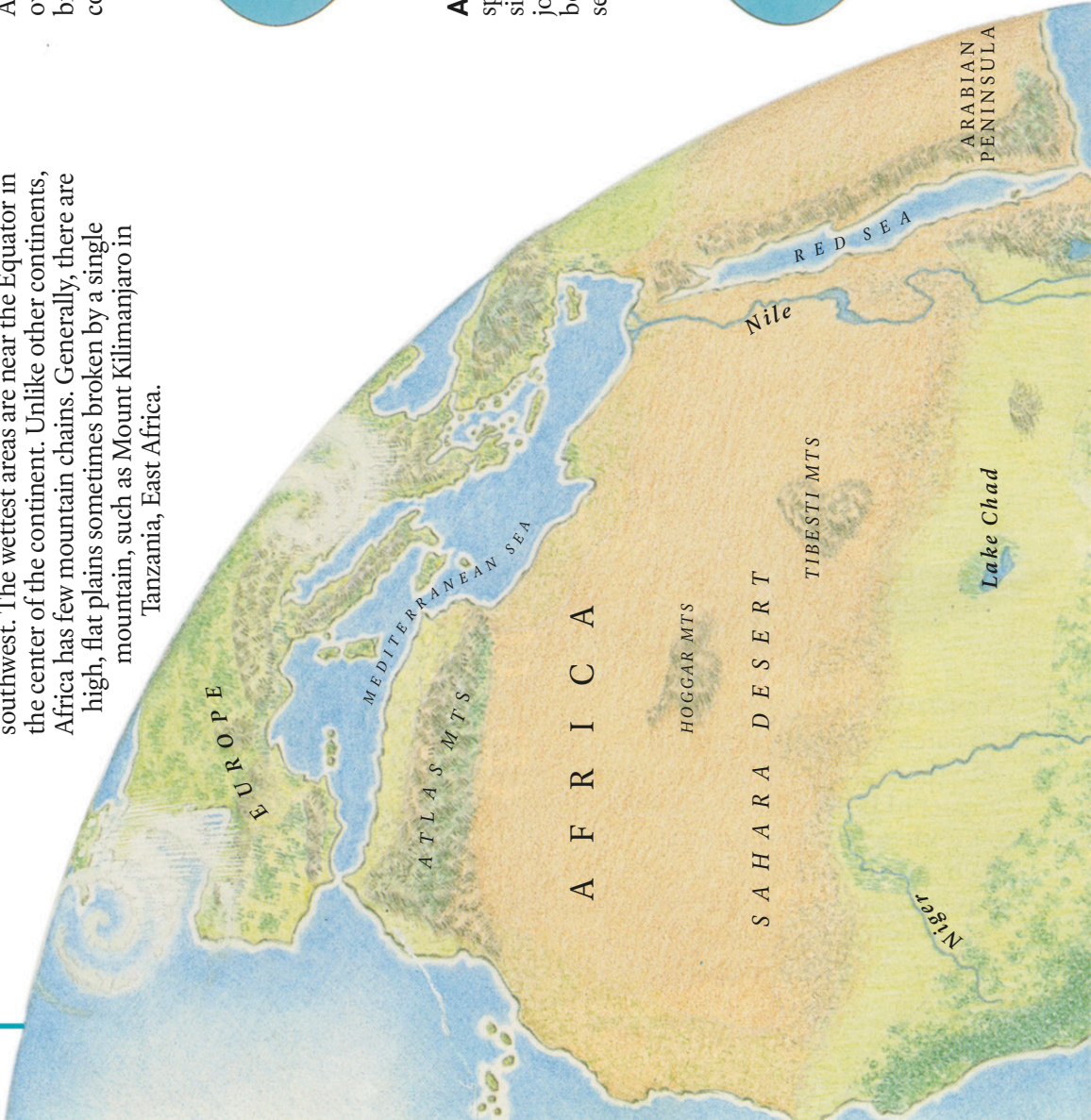
Africa is mainly a dry continent with large areas of desert and dry grassland. As a result, it has many land birds, especially seed-eaters.

Climate and landscape

Most of Africa has a hot climate, with large areas that receive very little rain, especially the Sahara desert in the north and the Namib and Kalahari deserts in the southwest. The wettest areas are near the Equator in the center of the continent. Unlike other continents, Africa has few mountain chains. Generally, there are high, flat plains sometimes broken by a single mountain, such as Mount Kilimanjaro in Tanzania, East Africa.

Africa on the move

Africa has not always been in the position it is in today. Like all the other continents, it has gradually shifted around Earth due to movements in the crust. Africa was once attached to the other continents, but over millions of years, it has drifted away. African birds evolved into many unique species because they could not mix with birds from other continents.



AMAZING BIRDS OF AFRICA

Most abundant bird

There are more red-billed queleas in the world than any other bird. Feeding flocks may contain millions of birds and colonies and can have up to 10 million nests.

Red-billed quelea
(*Quelea quelea*)



Longest toes

Relative to its body size, the African jacana has the longest toes: up to 3 in (8 cm) long.

Highest flier

A Rüppell's griffon vulture collided with a plane when flying over the coast of West Africa at an altitude of 36,988 ft (11,274 m). This is the highest altitude a bird has ever been seen at.

Broadest bill

The shoebill or whale-headed stork has the broadest bill of any bird—5 in (12 cm) wide.

Largest bird

The African common ostrich is the world's largest and tallest bird. Males can be up to 9 ft (2 m 70 cm) tall and weigh as much as 344 lb (156 kg). The ostrich also lays the largest eggs. A person can stand on one of these eggs without breaking it.

Common ostrich
(*Struthio camelus*)



About 130 million years ago, Africa started to split away from the other continents and became a single continent. At that time Madagascar was still joined to mainland Africa. Later, it drifted away to become an island, so the bird life there developed separately from that in mainland Africa.



In the last 100 million years, Africa has drifted toward Europe to its position on today's globe.